It was a busy period at the White House: I was getting ready for my first summit meeting with the new Soviet leader, Mikhail Gorbachev; there were important domestic legislative matters to deal with; we were watching events unfold in the Philippines that would lead to the downfall of Ferdinand Marcos; and intelligence people were continuing to get evidence that Libya was financing acts of terrorism—make that wanton murder—in several parts of the world. And the Middle East, seldom quiescent, had heated up again in early October when Israel bombed Arafat's PLO headquarters in Tunis.

The attack killed a number of women and children and touched off threats of reprisals from Palestinian radicals against Israel and the United States. Three days later, the Islamic Jihad announced it had executed one of the hostages—CIA man William Buckley—in retaliation for the attack on Tunis. (Later, we determined that Buckley had probably died from the effects of his captivity several months earlier.) And six days after the attack, four heavily armed Palestinians hijacked the Italian cruise ship *Achille Lauro* in the Mediterranean.

Once again, we had a crisis in the Middle East in which American lives were hanging in the balance. About one hundred passengers and crewmen, at least half of them Americans, were being held hostage on the ship, and the hijackers announced that they would soon begin murdering them, starting with the Americans, unless Israel released fifty Palestinian prisoners who were held in its jails. We spent much of the next forty-eight hours setting in motion a plan to deploy a crack team of navy Seals to assault the *Achille Lauro* and rescue the hostages from the terrorists. It was time, I said, to strike back at the terrorists, even though we all agreed that attacking the ship would be a high-risk operation.